SECRETARY OF WAR
1000 DEFENSE PENTAGON
WASHINGTON, DC 20301-1000

SEP 30 2026

MEMORANDUM FOR SENIOR PENTAGON LEADERSHIP
COMMANDERS OF THE COMBATANT COMMANDS
DEFENSE AGENCY AND DOW FIELD ACTIVITY DIRECTORS

SUBJECT: Commissioning of Project Meridian: The Future of Warfare

Under President Trump's leadership, the United States has the world's strongest, most lethal, and most capable military. Operations MIDNIGHT HAMMER, ABSOLUTE RESOLVE, and EPIC FURY showcased not only the skill and bravery of our warfighters, but also our unmatched technological prowess. However, the Department of War (DoW) must not take our current advantages for granted. We are witnessing rapid advances in artificial intelligence, autonomy, directed energy, robotics, biotechnology, among other critical high-tech areas. Combined, these new domains, new ways of fighting, and technological developments will profoundly alter the character of warfare. To maintain global dominance, the United States must anticipate future operational environments and act decisively to develop the tools to dominate in them.

Effective immediately, I am directing the DoW's Chief Technology Officer, Emil Michael, to commission Project Meridian: The Future of Warfare, through a partner organization. Project Meridian will study the battlefields of the future, identify which weapons and technologies warfighters will need to harness to dominate in these environments, and propose actionable solutions to start developing, testing and fielding these capabilities such that America will have overmatch for the 21st century and beyond. The Joint Staff and all services should be prepared to connect their future warfare efforts and research to Project Meridian.

Project Meridian will leverage critical perspectives from outside the Pentagon, drawing upon a group of top technologists, innovators, business leaders, policy makers, and national security experts. Project Meridian's primary function will be to map the trajectory of future warfare, identify critical capability gaps, and propose actionable solutions in furtherance of the identified goals in the 2026 National Security Science and Technology Strategy.

Project Meridian's finalized findings and recommendations shall be submitted to my office no later than 120 days after its announcement, or on January 28, 2027.

PBH

OSD010438-26/CMD013357-26